RDG-P5 · PRÁCTICA 01

Multiple choice

Hoja 01 · Artículo divulgativo · dificultad 1 de 4

6 preguntas (31–36) · 2 puntos por pregunta · tiempo orientativo: 18 minutos · sin consultar la teoría

You are going to read an article about memory. For questions 31–36, choose the answer (**A, B, C** or **D**) which you think fits best according to the text. Mark your answers on the answer sheet.

In defence of forgetting

Why a memory that lets things go may be smarter than one that keeps everything

Most of us treat forgetting as a small humiliation: the name that slips away mid-introduction, the misplaced keys, the reason we walked into the kitchen. We apologise for it, joke about it and, past a certain age, begin quietly to worry about it. The assumption behind all this embarrassment is that memory exists to store things, and that every lapse is a failure of storage, a leak in a vessel that ought to be watertight. It is an assumption that a growing number of neuroscientists now regard as not merely mistaken but back to front.

The idea that forgetting is a defect has a long and respectable pedigree. In the 1880s the German psychologist Hermann Ebbinghaus spent months memorising lists of nonsense syllables and testing himself at intervals, and the curve he plotted – steep loss within the first hours, then a long, slow decline – became one of the founding images of experimental psychology. For more than a century afterwards, the curve was read as a portrait of decay: something to be flattened, resisted and, if possible, abolished. Memory techniques, brain-training apps and a small industry of supplements have all been sold on the same promise, that with enough effort we might keep everything we put in.

Yet the rare individuals who come closest to that ideal are not obviously to be envied. The Russian neuropsychologist Alexander Luria spent some thirty years studying a man, known in his writings as S., who could reproduce long tables of numbers years after studying them for only a few minutes. S. made a living on the stage as a memory performer, but he found ordinary life surprisingly hard. He struggled to recognise people whose faces kept changing with their expressions, and he could make little of poetry or of any text that asked him to move beyond the literal, because each word summoned a vivid image that crowded out the sense of the whole. His difficulty, in other words, was not too little memory but too much.

Fiction had arrived at the same idea by another route. In a short story published in 1942, Jorge Luis Borges imagined a young man who, after being thrown from a horse, could forget nothing at all: every leaf on every tree, every shape of every cloud. Borges's narrator suspects that this prodigy was not very capable of thought, since thinking requires us to overlook differences, to generalise, to abstract. It is a striking intuition, and one that laboratory science was slow to take up.

The case was set out with particular clarity in 2017, when two neuroscientists at the University of Toronto, Blake Richards and Paul Frankland, argued that the purpose of memory is not to preserve information faithfully but to help us make good decisions. From that angle, forgetting earns its keep in two ways. First, the world changes: a memory of where food could be found last year, or of a route that has since been closed, is worse than useless if it overrides fresher information. Second, and less obviously, clinging to every detail of past experience makes it harder to extract the general pattern. A brain that remembered each individual dog it had ever met, down to the last whisker, might be slower to recognise a new one as a dog at all.

Researchers who build artificial intelligence will recognise the problem. A system trained too closely on its examples learns them by heart, quirks and all, and then performs poorly on anything new, a failure known as overfitting. One standard remedy is, in effect, a form of deliberate forgetting: during training, parts of the network are randomly switched off, so that no single pathway can hold on to too much detail. That engineers, working on quite different problems, should have arrived at something resembling the brain's own untidiness is, at the very least, suggestive.

None of this means that every lapse is a blessing in disguise. Forgetting caused by disease is a different matter altogether, and anyone who has watched dementia take hold of a parent would find the cheerful language of 'adaptive forgetting' hard to stomach. Nor does the research suggest that we should stop writing things down. What it does suggest is that the healthy brain is not a filing cabinet with a faulty lock but something closer to an editor, constantly deciding what is worth keeping and what can safely be let go.

That may be some consolation the next time a name escapes us at a party. The lapse is not necessarily a sign that the machinery is failing; it may simply mean that the machinery has judged, rightly or wrongly, that this particular name was not worth the space. We are, it turns out, built to forget, and we would be considerably worse off if we were not.

31 What does the writer suggest about the usual attitude to forgetting in the first paragraph?

A It reflects an exaggerated fear of growing old.
B It rests on a mistaken idea of what memory is for.
C It is shared by most of the scientists who study memory.
D It has more to do with embarrassment than with genuine concern.

32 The writer refers to the work of Ebbinghaus in order to

A show how a scientific finding came to be seen as evidence of a flaw.
B cast doubt on the methods of early experimental psychology.
C explain why memory techniques tend to be ineffective.
D illustrate how quickly people forget meaningless information.

33 What point does the writer make about S. in the third paragraph?

A His gift was accompanied by a talent for the arts.
B His abilities were exaggerated for the sake of performance.
C His memory left him unable to earn a living.
D His memory interfered with his ability to grasp meaning.

34 How does the writer present Borges's story in the fourth paragraph?

A as a fanciful idea that the evidence has failed to support
B as more persuasive than the scientific work that followed it
C as an imaginative insight that science later came to support
D as an exaggerated version of the case that Luria documented

35 What does the writer mean by saying that forgetting 'earns its keep'?

A It saves the brain energy that can then be used elsewhere.
B It becomes more valuable as people grow older.
C It is the price we pay for being able to decide quickly.
D It is useful enough to justify its place in memory.

36 What is the writer's main purpose in the article?

A to reassure readers that memory loss in later life need not worry them
B to challenge the belief that forgetting is simply a failure of memory
C to describe recent progress in the treatment of memory disorders
D to compare the workings of human memory with those of machines

Hoja de respuestas

Marca una sola letra por pregunta. Al corregir, 2 puntos por acierto; los errores no restan. Anota también el tiempo empleado: el objetivo en el examen son unos 18 minutos.

Nº	A	B	C	D	Puntos
31	A	B	C	D	/ 2
32	A	B	C	D	/ 2
33	A	B	C	D	/ 2
34	A	B	C	D	/ 2
35	A	B	C	D	/ 2
36	A	B	C	D	/ 2
				Total	**/ 12**

Tiempo empleado: _____ minutos.

SOLUCIONES

2 puntos por acierto. Cada solución indica el pasaje, una respuesta propia como la que pide el método (§2.2), por qué la clave es correcta y por qué falla cada distractor, con su tipo (§7) y la cita del texto que lo descarta. Los números de sección remiten a RDG-P5_Teoria_v1.

Clave rápida

Nº	Clave	Tipo de pregunta	Distractores	Teoría
31	**B**	Opinión y actitud	A §7.1/7.3 · C §7.4 · D §7.6	§4.1 · §6.1
32	**A**	Propósito	B §7.7 · C §7.5/7.7 · D §7.2	§5.1 · §5.2
33	**D**	Implicación	A §7.1 · B §7.1/7.7 · C §7.3	§3.2 · §6.2
34	**C**	Opinión y actitud	A §7.5 · B §7.3 · D §7.7	§4.2 · §5.2
35	**D**	Significado en contexto	A §7.7 · B §7.7/7.1 · C §7.5	§3.4
36	**B**	Global	A §7.3 · C §7.7 · D §7.3	§5.4 · §2.1

Explicación por pregunta

31 · B · Opinión y actitud

Pregunta: What does the writer suggest about the usual attitude to forgetting in the first paragraph?

Pasaje: párrafo 1. **Respuesta propia:** La actitud de siempre parte de una idea equivocada: que la memoria sirve para almacenarlo todo.

A It reflects an exaggerated fear of growing old.
Falla (eco léxico §7.1, alcance §7.3). Recoge past a certain age, begin quietly to worry about it, que es solo una de las reacciones que enumera el párrafo. El texto no dice que ese temor sea exagerado ni que explique la actitud general.

B It rests on a mistaken idea of what memory is for.
Correcta. El párrafo atribuye la vergüenza a un supuesto (The assumption behind all this embarrassment is that memory exists to store things) y lo descalifica en la última frase: not merely mistaken but back to front. La opción resume ese supuesto como una idea equivocada sobre para qué sirve la memoria.

C It is shared by most of the scientists who study memory.
Falla (voz §7.4). Invierte la postura de los científicos, que consideran esa idea not merely mistaken but back to front. Además, el texto habla de a growing number of neuroscientists, no de la mayoría (§6.4).

D It has more to do with embarrassment than with genuine concern.
Falla (medio cierto §7.6). La vergüenza sí aparece (all this embarrassment), pero también la preocupación real (begin quietly to worry about it), así que la comparación no se sostiene.

Teoría: §4.1 La voz del autor frente a las voces citadas · §6.1 Grados de paráfrasis

32 · A · Propósito

Pregunta: The writer refers to the work of Ebbinghaus in order to

Pasaje: párrafo 2. **Respuesta propia:** Para mostrar cómo una curva del olvido se leyó durante un siglo como prueba de un defecto que había que corregir.

A show how a scientific finding came to be seen as evidence of a flaw.
Correcta. El párrafo abre con la idea que va a ilustrar (The idea that forgetting is a defect has a long and respectable pedigree), y Ebbinghaus es su origen: su curva was read as a portrait of decay, algo que había que combatir. El verbo was read indica que al autor le interesa la interpretación del hallazgo, no el hallazgo en sí.

B cast doubt on the methods of early experimental psychology.
Falla (ausente §7.7). El autor no critica el método: describe el experimento sin reservas y lo presenta como one of the founding images of experimental psychology.

C explain why memory techniques tend to be ineffective.
Falla (lógica §7.5, ausente §7.7). El texto dice que esos productos have all been sold on the same promise: relaciona la promesa comercial con la lectura de la curva, pero no afirma que no funcionen.

D illustrate how quickly people forget meaningless information.
Falla (no responde §7.2). Es cierto que la curva muestra una pérdida rápida (steep loss within the first hours), pero ese es el contenido del ejemplo, no su función en el argumento (§5.1).

Teoría: §5.1 Para qué sirve un fragmento · §5.2 Verbos de función en las opciones

33 · D · Implicación

Pregunta: What point does the writer make about S. in the third paragraph?

Pasaje: párrafo 3. **Respuesta propia:** Recordar tanto le impedía entender: los detalles tapaban el sentido.

A His gift was accompanied by a talent for the arts.
Falla (eco léxico §7.1). Junta on the stage y poetry, pero sobre la poesía el texto dice lo contrario: S. no la entendía.

B His abilities were exaggerated for the sake of performance.
Falla (eco léxico §7.1, ausente §7.7). Toma memory performer y le añade una sospecha que el texto no plantea. Luria comprobó que S. recordaba las tablas years after studying them for only a few minutes.

C His memory left him unable to earn a living.
Falla (alcance §7.3). Lo contradice S. made a living on the stage. Que he found ordinary life surprisingly hard no significa que no pudiera ganarse la vida.

D His memory interfered with his ability to grasp meaning.
Correcta. S. could make little of poetry or of any text that asked him to move beyond the literal, porque cada palabra evocaba una imagen que crowded out the sense of the whole. La última frase lo resume: not too little memory but too much. La opción abstrae el caso concreto (§6.2).

Teoría: §3.2 De dónde sale una inferencia · §6.2 Lo concreto del texto, lo abstracto de la opción

34 · C · Opinión y actitud

Pregunta: How does the writer present Borges's story in the fourth paragraph?

Pasaje: párrafos 4 y 5. **Respuesta propia:** Como una intuición literaria acertada, a la que la ciencia llegó más tarde.

A as a fanciful idea that the evidence has failed to support
Falla (lógica §7.5). Invierte la relación: la ciencia no ha refutado la intuición, sino que ha acabado dándole forma (The case was set out with particular clarity in 2017).

B as more persuasive than the scientific work that followed it
Falla (alcance §7.3). La expresión a striking intuition es un elogio, pero el texto no compara el cuento con la investigación ni dice que convenza más.

C as an imaginative insight that science later came to support
Correcta. Borges llegó a la misma idea by another route, y el autor la valora como a striking intuition. La ciencia tardó en asumirla (laboratory science was slow to take up), pero el párrafo siguiente muestra que acabó haciéndolo: The case was set out with particular clarity in 2017.

D as an exaggerated version of the case that Luria documented
Falla (ausente §7.7). El texto no relaciona el cuento con el caso de Luria ni lo considera exagerado: dice que la ficción llegó a la idea by another route, es decir, por su cuenta.

Teoría: §4.2 Marcadores de postura · §5.2 Verbos de función en las opciones

35 · D · Significado en contexto

Pregunta: What does the writer mean by saying that forgetting 'earns its keep'?

Pasaje: párrafo 5. **Respuesta propia:** Que el olvido sirve para algo y por eso merece existir.

A It saves the brain energy that can then be used elsewhere.
Falla (ausente §7.7). Lee la expresión en clave de ahorro, pero el texto no menciona la energía: las dos ventajas que enumera sirven para decidir mejor (help us make good decisions).

B It becomes more valuable as people grow older.
Falla (ausente §7.7, eco léxico §7.1). Nada en el párrafo relaciona las ventajas del olvido con la edad, que solo aparece en el primero, a propósito de la preocupación (past a certain age).

C It is the price we pay for being able to decide quickly.
Falla (lógica §7.5). El olvido no es el coste de decidir rápido, sino lo que permite decidir bien (help us make good decisions). Presentarlo como un precio contradice la propia expresión, que habla de un beneficio.

D It is useful enough to justify its place in memory.
Correcta. Earn one's keep es «ganarse el sustento, justificar lo que uno cuesta». El contexto lo explica enseguida: el olvido aporta dos ventajas (forgetting earns its keep in two ways), porque el mundo cambia y porque recordar cada detalle makes it harder to extract the general pattern.

Teoría: §3.4 Significado en contexto

36 · B · Global

Pregunta: What is the writer's main purpose in the article?

Pasaje: el texto completo. **Respuesta propia:** Desmontar la idea de que olvidar es un fallo: olvidar forma parte del buen funcionamiento de la memoria.

A to reassure readers that memory loss in later life need not worry them
Falla (alcance §7.3). El autor deja fuera la enfermedad (Forgetting caused by disease is a different matter altogether), y el consuelo final se limita a olvidos cotidianos, como un nombre en una fiesta.

B to challenge the belief that forgetting is simply a failure of memory
Correcta. El primer párrafo presenta la idea que se va a discutir (cada olvido sería a failure of storage) y el último da la conclusión: We are, it turns out, built to forget. Todo lo intermedio (Luria, Borges, Richards y Frankland, la inteligencia artificial) son pruebas al servicio de esa tesis.

C to describe recent progress in the treatment of memory disorders
Falla (ausente §7.7). El texto no habla de tratamientos: la demencia solo aparece para excluirla del argumento (anyone who has watched dementia take hold of a parent).

D to compare the workings of human memory with those of machines
Falla (alcance §7.3). La comparación con la inteligencia artificial ocupa un solo párrafo y es un apoyo más, que el autor presenta con cautela (at the very least, suggestive).

Teoría: §5.4 Preguntas globales · §2.1 Primera lectura: el mapa del texto